

Anthony M. Yacovone

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Department of Linguistics, Boston University

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Principal Investigator, Duckling Lab

Developmental Underpinnings of Cognition & Kid Linguistics

Department of Linguistics
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ACADEMIC APPOINTMENTS

Assistant Professor, Department of Linguistics
Boston University, Boston, MA

July 2025 – present

Postdoctoral Research Fellow, Department of Psychology
Tufts University, Medford, MA

June 2023 – 2025

Non-clinical Research Fellow, Department of Psychiatry
Massachusetts General Hospital/Harvard Medical School, Boston, MA

June 2023 – 2025

EDUCATION

Ph.D., Psychology 2023
Harvard University, Cambridge, MA
Advisor: Jesse Snedeker

Dissertation: *Grape Expectations: A collection of EEG stories on form-based prediction in natural language contexts*

A.M., Psychology 2019
Harvard University, Cambridge, MA
Advisor: Jesse Snedeker

B.A., Linguistics and Psychology, *summa cum laude* 2016
B.A., Linguistics and Spanish, *summa cum laude*
University of Massachusetts Amherst, Amherst, MA
Advisors: Brian Dillon, Lyn Frazier

GRANTS & FELLOWSHIPS

Henry A. Rand Fund, Harvard Innovation Award, Harvard University 2023 – 2026
Investigating linguistic prediction in American Sign Language.

Role: Principal Investigator
 Amount Awarded: \$10,000

Dissertation Completion Fellowship, Harvard University 2022 – 2023
Grape Expectations: Investigating form-based prediction during naturalistic comprehension
 Amount Awarded: \$42,704

Restricted Funds Large Research Grant, Harvard University 2022 – 2023
Evaluating the representational content of linguistic and non-linguistic predictions from early childhood to adulthood.

Role: Principal Investigator
 Amount Awarded: \$5,000

Mind Brain Behavior Initiative Research Grant, Harvard University 2020 – 2023
Investigating linguistic prediction in American Sign Language.
 Role: Principal Investigator
 Amount Awarded: \$8,000

Barbara Ditmars Fund, Harvard University 2018 – 2020
Evaluating the use of world knowledge as a top-down constraint on interpretation.
 Role: Principal Investigator
 Amount Awarded: \$3,500

Sosland Family Graduate Fellowship, Harvard University 2017 – 2018
 Amount Awarded: \$35,594

Elsie Hopestill Stimson Fund Research Grant, Harvard University 2017 – 2018
 Role: Principal Investigator
 Amount Awarded: \$1,000

Commonwealth Honors College Research Grant, UMass Amherst 2015 – 2016
 Amount Awarded: \$500

AWARDS & HONORS

Restricted Funds Small Travel Award, Harvard University 2017, 2023

Certificate of Distinction and Excellence in Teaching, Harvard University 2019
 Course: *Statistics for the Behavioral Sciences*

Student Travel Award, Conference on Human Sentence Processing 2017, 2018

Honors Dean's Award, UMass Amherst 2016

Dean's List Honors, UMass Amherst 2012 – 2016

Phi Beta Kappa Honors Society 2015

WORK IN PROGRESS

Trainee authors/presenters are underlined.

Yacovone, A., Carter, J., Kocab, A., Davidson, K., & Snedeker, J. (in revision). *Linguistic modality (hand)shapes your expectations: An EEG study of form-based predictions during naturalistic comprehension of stories in American Sign Language.*

Yacovone, A., Waite, B., & Snedeker, J. (in preparation). Prediction is a piece of *ceke*: An EEG study of form-based prediction in young children during storytelling contexts.

PEER-REVIEWED PUBLICATIONS

[Google Scholar Profile](#)

Trainee authors/presenters are underlined.

Waite, B., **Yacovone, A.**, & Snedeker, J. (2025). Case *Clozed*: Young Children Can Explicitly Predict Upcoming Words in a Naturalistic, Story-based Cloze Task. *Journal of Child Language*, 1-25.

Yacovone, A. (2025). *The Garden Path to Literacy: How Syntax Guides Children's Comprehension, and Why We Should Teach Young Readers About It. Perspectives on Language and Literacy*, Volume 51, No. 1, 34-37.

Yacovone, A., Waite, B., Levari, T., & Snedeker, J. (2024). Let them eat *ceke*: An electrophysiological study of form-based prediction in rich naturalistic contexts. *Journal of Experimental Psychology: General*, 154(3), 711–738.

Slim, M. S., Kandel, M., **Yacovone, A.**, & Snedeker, J. (2024). Webcams as windows to the mind? A direct comparison between in-lab and web-based eye-tracking methods. *Open Mind*, 8, 1369-1424.

Brothers, T., Morgan, E., **Yacovone, A.**, & Kuperberg, G.R. (2023). Multiple predictions during language comprehension: Friends, foes, or indifferent companions? *Cognition*, 241, 105602.

Yacovone, A., Shafto, C. L., Worek, A., & Snedeker, J. (2021). Word vs. World Knowledge: A developmental shift from bottom-up lexical cues to top-down plausibility. *Cognitive Psychology*, 131, 101442.

Yacovone, A., Moya, E., & Snedeker, J. (2021). Unexpected words or unexpected languages? Two ERP effects of code-switching in naturalistic discourse. *Cognition*, 215, 104814.

Yacovone, A., Rigby, I., & Omaki, A. (2020). Children's comprehension and repair of garden-path wh-questions. *Language Acquisition*, 27(4), 363-396.

Rysling, A., Bishop, J., Clifton Jr, C., & **Yacovone, A.** (2020). Preceding syllables are necessary for the accent advantage effect. *The Journal of the Acoustical Society of America*, 148(3), EL285-EL288.

Omaki, A., Ovans, Z., **Yacovone, A.**, & Dillon, B. (2019). Rebels without a clause: Processing reflexives in fronted wh-predicates. *Journal of Memory and Language*, 107, 80-94.

INVITED ACADEMIC TALKS

<i>Departmental Colloquium</i> , Linguistics, Boston University, Boston, MA	2026, 2024
<i>Invited Seminar</i> for DISCOURSE in Psychosis Consortium [Talk available here]	2025
<i>Departmental Colloquium</i> , Linguistics, UC Santa Cruz, Santa Cruz, CA	2024
<i>Language Development Dept.</i> , Max Planck Institute for Psycholinguistics, Nijmegen, NL	2023
<i>Language and Cognition Colloquium</i> , Harvard University, Cambridge, MA	2022, 2017
<i>NeuroCognition of Language Lab</i> , Tufts University, Medford, MA	2022
<i>Virtual Workshop on Virtual Eye-tracking</i> , Boston College, Chestnut Hill, MA	2021
<i>Machine Commonsense Meeting</i> , MIT, Cambridge, MA	2020
<i>Computation & Language Talk Series</i> , MIT, Cambridge, MA	2020
<i>The Language Lab</i> , MIT, Cambridge, MA	2018

CONFERENCE TALKS AND POSTER PRESENTATIONS

Trainee authors/presenters are underlined. ~ presented virtually.

Waite, B., Levari, T., **Yacovone**, A., & Snedeker, J. (November 2025). The development of prediction during naturalistic listening: ERP evidence for improved top-down processing with age and language ability. Talk at 50th *Annual Boston University Conference on Language Development*, Boston University, Boston, MA, USA.

Levari, T., Waite, B., Shine, H., **Yacovone**, A., & Snedeker, J. (November 2025). Lexical prediction in children with and without autism during naturalistic listening. Poster at 50th *Annual Boston University Conference on Language Development*, Boston University, Boston, MA, USA.

Van Dyke, J., Powell-Smith, K., Cardenas-Hagan, E., Eberhardt, N., Fedorenko, E., Gatlin-Nash, B., . . . **Yacovone**, A. (October 2025). Syntax Comes First: Understanding How Syntax is the Backbone of Comprehension. Invited symposia at *IDA 2025: Annual Reading, Literacy & Learning Conference*. Atlanta, Georgia.

Yacovone, A., & Van Dyke, J. (October 2025). Science of Language Comprehension: Evidence about how the brain comprehends language. Symposium presented at *IDA 2025: Annual Reading, Literacy & Learning Conference*. Atlanta, GA, USA.

Yacovone, A., Nour Eddine, S., Hansen, T., & Kuperberg, G. (September 2025). Late Frontal Positivities during self-paced reading are sensitive to lexical predictability, not misprediction: Evidence from EEG and Predictive Coding simulations. Poster at *Society for the Neurobiology of Language 17th Annual Meeting*, Gallaudet University, Washington DC.

Hansen, T., **Yacovone**, A., Nour Eddine, S., & Kuperberg, G. (September 2025). Bottom-up and top-down propagation of residual information across the left fronto-temporal cortex during sentence comprehension: Converging evidence from M/EEG and predictive coding simulations. Poster at *Society for the Neurobiology of Language 17th Annual Meeting*, Gallaudet University, Washington DC.

- Waite, B., **Yacovone, A.**, Levari, T., & Snedeker, J. (September 2025). *The development of lexical access and linguistic prediction: Adapting story-based EEG tasks to understand comprehension in preschoolers*. Poster at *Society for the Neurobiology of Language 17th Annual Meeting*, Gallaudet University, Washington DC.
- Hansen, T., **Yacovone, A.**, Fung, I., & Kuperberg, G. (March 2025). Changing the narrative: ERP markers of building and updating situation models during deep naturalistic comprehension. Poster at *38th Annual Conference on Human Sentence Processing*, University of Maryland, College Park, College Park, MD, USA.
- Huang, Y., **Yacovone, A.**, & Snedeker, J. (March 2025). Switching meanings and forms: An ERP study on multilingual language processing in Mandarin-English bilinguals. Poster at *38th Annual Conference on Human Sentence Processing*, University of Maryland, College Park, College Park, MD, USA.
- Waite, B., Levari, T., **Yacovone, A.**, & Snedeker, J. (March 2025). Lexical access during naturalistic listening in middle childhood and early adolescence. Poster at *38th Annual Conference on Human Sentence Processing*, University of Maryland, College Park, College Park, MD, USA.
- Waite, B., Levari, T., **Yacovone, A.**, & Snedeker, J. (November 2024). Lexical access in naturalistic listening during middle childhood and early adolescence. Poster at *49th Boston University Conference on Language Development*, Boston University, Boston, MA, USA.
- Hansen, T., **Yacovone, A.**, Wang, L., & Kuperberg, G. (May 2024). Homographs revisited: ERP insights into the dynamic interplay between top-down predictive and bottom-up reactive processes. Poster at *37th Annual Conference on Human Sentence Processing*, University of Michigan, Ann Arbor, MI, USA.
- Yacovone, A.**, Waite, B., & Snedeker, J. (May 2024). Form-based prediction is a piece of ceke: Young children predict the form of upcoming words during natural storytelling contexts. Poster at *37th Annual Conference on Human Sentence Processing*, University of Michigan, Ann Arbor, MI, USA.
- Waite, B., **Yacovone, A.**, & Snedeker, J. (November 2023). Children make robust lexical predictions in a naturalistic context. Poster at *48th Boston University Conference on Language Development*, Boston University, Boston, MA, USA.
- Waite, B., **Yacovone, A.**, & Snedeker, J. (March 2023). Children make robust lexical predictions in a naturalistic context. Poster at *36th Annual Conference on Human Sentence Processing*, University of Pittsburgh, Pittsburgh, PA, USA.
- ~ Slim., M., Kandel, M., **Yacovone, A.**, Presgrave, M., & Snedeker, J. (September 2022). Comparing web-based and in-lab eye-tracking tools for language experiments. Short remote talk at the *28th Architectures and Mechanisms for Language Processing* conference, University of York, York, UK.
- ~ **Yacovone, A.**, Waite, B., Levari, T., & Snedeker, J. (March 2022). Let them eat ceke: an EEG study of form-based prediction in rich naturalistic contexts. Short remote talk at the *35th Annual Conference on Human Sentence Processing*, University of California, Santa Cruz, Santa Cruz, CA, USA.

- ~ Kandel, M., **Yacovone, A.**, Slim, M., & Snedeker, J. (March 2022). Webcams as windows to the mind: comparing web-based eye-tracking methods. Short remote talk at the 35th *Annual Conference on Human Sentence Processing*, University of California, Santa Cruz, Santa Cruz, CA, USA.
- ~ Poliak, M., **Yacovone, A.**, & Snedeker, J. (March 2022). Between you and me: Use ERP decoding when between-participants variation is high. Short remote talk at the 35th *Annual Conference on Human Sentence Processing*, University of California, Santa Cruz, Santa Cruz, CA, USA.
- ~ **Yacovone, A.**, Poliak, M., Koya, H., & Snedeker, J. (March 2021). ERP decoding shows bilinguals represent the language of a code-switch after lexical processing. Short remote talk at the 34th *CUNY Human Sentence Processing Conference*, University of Pennsylvania, Philadelphia, PA, USA.
- ~ **Yacovone, A.**, Piowarczyk, P., & Snedeker, J. (March 2021). It takes two the tango: Predictability and detectability affect processing of phrase structure errors. Short remote talk at the 34th *CUNY Human Sentence Processing Conference*, University of Pennsylvania, Philadelphia, PA, USA.
- Yacovone, A.**, Moya, E., & Snedeker, J. (March 2019). Investigating the costs of intra-sentential code-switching for lexical processes. Poster at the 32nd *CUNY Human Sentence Processing Conference*, University of Colorado, Boulder, Boulder, CO, USA.
- Yacovone, A.**, Göbel, A. (May 2018). Question others, not yourself! Do QUDs affect naturalness within and across speakers? Poster at the *Festschrift conference for Dr. Lyn Frazier*, UMass Amherst, Amherst, MA, USA.
- Yacovone, A.**, Shafto, C., Worek, A., & Snedeker, J. (March 2018). Developmental shifts from bottom-up lexical biases to top-down plausibility in syntactic parsing. Poster at the 31st *CUNY Human Sentence Processing Conference*, University of California, Davis, Davis, CA, USA.
- Yacovone, A.**, & Omaki, A. (January 2018). Children's comprehension and repair of garden-path *wh*-questions in English. Poster at the 92nd Annual Meeting of the *Linguistic Society of America*, Salt Lake City, Utah, USA.
- Yacovone, A.**, Dillon, B., & Frazier, L. (March 2017). High predictability temporarily down-weights errors in subject-verb agreement. Poster at the 30th *CUNY Human Sentence Processing Conference*, Massachusetts Institute of Technology, Cambridge, MA, USA.
- Rysling, A., Clifton Jr., C., Bishop, J., & **Yacovone, A.** (March 2017). Listeners rely on local context, not global prosody, to anticipate pitch accents. Poster at the 30th *CUNY Conference on Human Sentence Processing*. Massachusetts Institute of Technology, Cambridge, MA, USA.
- Rysling, A., Kingston, J., Staub, A., Cohen, A., Starns, J., & **Yacovone, A.** (November 2016). Lexical knowledge is available, but not always used, very early. Poster at the *Psychonomic Society 57th Annual Meeting*. Boston, MA, USA.

Clifton Jr., C., Frazier, L., & **Yacovone, A.** (September 2016). Likelihood of Epistemic State Affects Sentence Naturalness. Poster at the 22nd *Architectures and Mechanisms for Language Processing* conference, Basque Center on Cognition, Brain, and Language, Bilbao, Spain.

Andrews., C., **Yacovone, A.**, Sloggett, S., & Dillon, B. (September 2016). Reflexives: We don't see the attraction. Poster at the 22nd *Architectures and Mechanisms for Language Processing* conference, Basque Center on Cognition, Brain, and Language, Bilbao, Spain.

Yacovone, A. (May 2016). Investigating the role of predictability during syntactic resolution. Poster at the 22nd Annual Massachusetts Statewide Undergraduate Research Conference, University of Massachusetts Amherst, Amherst, MA, USA.

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Boston University — Department of Linguistics

Topics in Linguistics: Psycholinguistics	LX 390/590/690 (A1)	Spring 2026
Topics in Linguistics: Child Language Acquisition	LX 390/690 (A1)	Fall 2025
Seminar in Linguistics Research, <i>Guest Speaker</i>	LX 801	Fall 2025
Introduction to Linguistics, <i>Guest Lecturer</i>	LX 250	Fall 2025

Tufts University — Department of Psychology

Cognitive Science of Language, <i>Guest Lecturer</i>	Fall 2023
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Harvard University — Department of Psychology

Senior Tutorial: Honors Thesis in Psychology, <i>Department Statistics Consultant</i>	2020–2021
Developmental Psychology, <i>Teaching Fellow</i>	Spring 2020
Statistics for the Behavioral Sciences, <i>Teaching Fellow</i>	Fall 2019

MENTORING

PhD Dissertation Committees

Paris Gappmayr	Boston University, <i>Sargent College</i>	Internal Member	2025
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MA Committees

Apoorva Vallampati	Tufts University, <i>Psychology</i>	External Member	2025
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Undergraduate Thesis Students

*Awarded research grant; †Won the Harvard Psychology Faculty Prize

Ivi Fung	Tufts University, <i>Psychology</i>	2025
Timothy Guest	University of Bath (UK), <i>Psychology</i>	2024
Jenna Hughes	University of Bath (UK), <i>Psychology</i>	2023
Moshe Poliak*†	Harvard University, <i>Psychology</i>	2021
Paulina Piwowarczyk*	Harvard University, <i>Neuroscience & Linguistics</i>	2020
Emily Moya*	Harvard University, <i>Psychology</i>	2019
Jerry Nelluvelil*	Harvard University, <i>Neuroscience & Linguistics</i>	2018

Graduate Research Mentees (Current)

*Former research assistant before their graduate training

Romi Hill	PhD	Boston University, <i>Linguistics</i>	2026 – present
Ahmad Hamssa	PhD	Boston University, <i>Linguistics</i>	2026 – present
Xinhan Jiang	PhD	Boston University, <i>Linguistics</i>	2026 – present
Jessica Carter*	PhD	Johns Hopkins University, <i>Cognitive Science</i>	2020 – present
Briony Waite*	PhD	Harvard University, <i>Psychology</i>	2020 – present
Yuhui Huang	PhD	Harvard University, <i>Psychology</i>	2023 – present
Thomas Hansen	PhD	Tufts University, <i>Psychology</i>	2023 – present
Apoorva Vallampati	PhD	Tufts University, <i>Psychology</i>	2023 – present
Baylee Ross	MA	Boston University, <i>Linguistics</i>	
I Meng Lin	MA	Boston University, <i>Linguistics</i>	

Graduate Research Mentees (Former)

Samer Nour Eddine	PhD	Tufts University, <i>Psychology</i>	2023 – 2025
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Undergraduate Sponsored Researchers

Noah Darby	Boston University	Undergraduate Research Opportunities Program	2026
Christopher Miyai	Boston University	Undergraduate Research Opportunities Program	2026
Moshe Poliak	Harvard University	Build Learning through Inquiry in Social Sciences	2020
Paulina Piwowarczyk	Harvard University	Build Learning through Inquiry in Social Sciences	2019
Maribelle Dickins	Harvard University	Build Learning through Inquiry in Social Sciences	2018

Undergraduate Research Assistants (Current)

Noah Darby	Boston University, <i>Linguistics</i>	2026 – present
Christopher Miyai	Boston University, <i>Computer Science & Linguistics</i>	2026 – present
Tofe Akinyanmi	Boston University, <i>Linguistics</i>	2026 – present
Yujing Wang	Boston University, <i>Anthropology & Neuroscience</i>	2026 – present
Rafaella Nunes	Boston University, <i>Neuroscience</i>	2026 – present
Sayge Rolnick	Boston University, <i>Linguistics</i>	2026 – present
Suhani Shah	Boston University, <i>Neuroscience</i>	2026 – present
Monique Lin	Tufts University, <i>Cognitive Science & Linguistics</i>	2026 – present

Undergraduate Research Assistants (Former)

Timothy Guest	University of Bath (UK)	2022 – 2024
Moshe Poliak	Harvard University → PhD, MIT (Brain & Cognitive Science)	2020 – 2023
Oluwatobi Abubakare	University of Rochester → PhD, Boston College (Psychology)	2019 – 2023
Eleanor Muir	University of Bath (UK)	2022 – 2023
Jenna Hughes	University of Bath (UK)	2021 – 2023
Madeleine Presgrave	University of Bath (UK)	2021 – 2022
Harita Koya	New York University → MSW, Smith College	2021 – 2021
Beatriz Leitao	University of Bath (UK) → MS, IE University (Business)	2020 – 2021
Charlotte Kennish	University of Bath (UK) → MS, EDHEC (Management)	2019 – 2020
Hillarie Man	University of Bath (UK) → PhD, UCL (Language & Cognition)	2019 – 2020
Paulina Piwowarczyk	Harvard University → MD, Northwestern	2018 – 2020
Karen Andres	Harvard University → MS, Harvard (Education)	2018 – 2020
Emily Moya	Harvard University → MD, Stanford	2018 – 2019
Jerry Nelluvelil	Harvard University → MS, Harvard (Education)	2017 – 2018

Undergraduate Summer Interns

Siva Zhou	Pomona College → PhD, Stanford (Linguistics)	Summer 2022
Kate Kaufman	University of Virginia	Summer 2022
Barbora Hlachova	UMass Amherst → PhD, UC Davis (Linguistics)	Summer 2021
Praneetha Inampudi	UT Austin → MD, Columbia (Dental)	Summer 2021
Moshe Poliak	Harvard University → PhD, MIT (BCS)	Summer 2020
Paulina Piwowarczyk	Harvard University → MD, Northwestern	Summer 2019
Maribelle Dickins	Harvard University	Summer 2018

PROFESSIONAL SERVICE

To the profession

Faculty Advisor for Boston University Conference on Language Development	2024 – present
Pop-Up Mentoring Program (PUMP) @ BUCLD 50	2025
Language and Cognition Colloquia Series (Hosted at Harvard, <i>Co-organizer</i>)	2018 – 2020
<i>Prediction in Language Event (Panel Moderator)</i>	2021
Panelists: G. Kuperberg, R. Jackendoff, R. Levy, J. Snedeker, B. Dillon	

To the department**Boston University – Linguistics**

Undergraduate Engagement and Curriculum Task Force (<i>Member</i>)	2025 – present
Doctoral Student Admissions Committee (<i>Reviewer/Interviewer</i>)	2025 – 2026
Undergraduate Major Fair (<i>Department Representative</i>)	2025
Academic Program Review of the Linguistics Department (<i>Participant</i>)	2024 – 2025

Harvard University – Psychology

Diversity, Inclusion, Belonging (DIB) Committee (<i>Member</i>)	2020 – 2023
Prospective PhD & RA Event in Psychology (PPREP, <i>Co-organizer</i>)	2020 – 2022
Summer Workshop: Foundations of EEG research (<i>Organizer</i>)	2019 – 2022
Developmental Psychology Brown Bag Talk Series (<i>Co-organizer</i>)	2020 – 2021

Ad-hoc Reviewing

Grants: *National Science Foundation (Perception, Action and Cognition Program).*

Journals: *Behavior Research Methods; Cognition; Developmental Science; Journal of Memory and Language; Language, Cognition, and Neuroscience.*

Conferences: *Conference on Human Sentence Processing; Boston University Conference on Language Development.*

PROFESSIONAL AFFILIATIONS

Diverse International Scientific Consortium for Research in Thought Language and Communication (DISCOURSE) in Psychosis; Society for Neurobiology of Language; Cognitive Neuroscience Society; Society for Human Sentence Processing; Linguistic Society of America.

TECHNICAL SKILLS

Languages

English (Native), *Spanish* (Proficient), *Italian* (Proficient), *American Sign Language* (Beginner).

Methodology

Electroencephalography (EEG/ERPs), *Magnetoencephalography* (MEG/ERFs), *Functional/Structural Magnetic Resonance Imaging* (f/sMRI); *Eye-tracking* (Visual World Paradigm, web-based eye-tracking, eye-tracking-while-reading, self-paced reading, pupillometry); *Behavioral and perceptual tasks* (error detection, phoneme monitoring, psycholinguistic judgments, cloze procedures).

Programming

R, *R Studio*, *Python*, *MATLAB*, *Praat*, *JavaScript*.

Statistics/Analytic Approaches

Multilevel regression, *Mass univariate analyses for timeseries data* (EEG, MEG, eye-tracking), *Functional regression*, *Bayesian inference*, *Representational Similarity Analyses* (RSA), *Neural decoding* (machine learning techniques), *Exploratory Factor Analyses*.